

**MAMASPEAK**
"When you see a child grow, time takes on a different perspective," says Koechlin

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**KALKI KOECHLIN DOESN'T DO PREDICTABLE.** When she first performed a short, sharp snippet from her graphic novel, *The Elephant in the Womb*, at a Kommune show in 2024, it was clear that her take on the maternal experience was never going to be run-of-the-mill. Standing there watching her was director Sheena Khalid. A mutual admiration evolved into a conversation, a pitch to Aadyam Theatre and, eventually, a desire to turn those pages into a stage play.

Two years later, that spark has culminated in *Belly of the Beast*, a production that involves the world of shadow puppetry, overhead projectors, and five women transforming into mythical creatures—vampires, werewolves, and spider demons—to articulate the unspeakable emotional upheavals of motherhood. It is darkly funny and visually inventive. On Aadyam's social media page, Koechlin—who has co-written the play with Khalid and is acting in it—says the play is about "the absolute fragility of your own mortality".

**KOECHLIN AND DIRECTOR SHEENA KHALID CHOSE TO CHANNEL THE PSYCHOLOGICAL WEIGHT OF MOTHERHOOD INTO A CONTEMPORARY MYTH, TO "MAKE IT LARGER THAN LIFE"**

When pressed on what that reaction truly means, the actor candidly says, "At the clinic, when you are handed your baby who is the size of a large croissant, you are so terrified that it might die. You're up 24/7, keeping it alive. Your mind is constantly thinking about what could go wrong," adding how when her daughter Sappho was born, the umbilical cord was loosely around her neck. "There are many moments through pregnancy where you feel vulnerable. You think about death all the time when you have new life in your hands. I think the idea of death is very closely linked with birth," she muses.

The play follows five women at different stages of motherhood, from pregnancy and labour to postpartum life, raising young children and learning to let go. To capture an experience so "indescribable and epic", Koechlin and Khalid turned to the extraordinary—choosing to channel the psychological weight of motherhood into a contemporary myth. "We wanted to make it larger than life, and to make it into this sort of metaphor of becoming these new creatures," Koechlin explains. "You lose who you are, in some ways, when you become a mother, but you gain something else. That's the idea of transformation."

As a director, Khalid found herself tasked with finding a physical language for the play. While its roots lie firmly in Koechlin's written words, the rehearsal room demanded more. "We started looking at the book and thought about a structure that was very close to it. But the more we got into these creatures—these spider demons and vampires—and the folklore around them, the more it started evolving. Now, the show is a completely different beast of its own," she says.

The irony of the gruelling rehearsal schedule isn't lost on Koechlin. "We're making a play on motherhood and I'm not spending any time with my daughter," she says, with a resigned smile. Motherhood, says Koechlin, has been a journey of contrasts—losing a fiercely-guarded independence and gaining an awareness of the present moment. "There is a certain part of you that